AISS (Erasmus Mundus): Submission Pack

Official project name SITeS-JM, Sustainable Information Technologies for Societies Joint Masters. Degree programme branded ‘AISS: Artificial Intelligence for Sustainable Societies’. Window 2 Dec 2026 – 2 Feb 2027

Nothing is submitted, signed, sent or paid for you.

Evidence:

- **E1:** verified on the official site
- **E2:** search-indexed official page, not opened from this session (confirm in your browser)

1. Identity and official links (E1)

- The EU’s Erasmus Mundus catalogue (eacea.ec.europa.eu) lists **SITeS-JM, “Sustainable Information Technologies for Societies Joint Masters”**, with the website **aissprogram.eu**.
- That site presents the degree as the **“AISS Master’s program”** within the **SITeS project**, co-funded by the EU through the Erasmus Mundus Joint Masters programme.
- **Partners:** Tallinn University (coordinator, Estonia), Lusófona University (Portugal), Tampere University (Finland).
- **Programme:** https://aissprogram.eu/
- **Application procedure:** https://aissprogram.eu/application-procedure/ (the application itself is filed in Tallinn University’s DreamApply; follow the “Apply” link on that page from 2 Dec)
- **Scholarships:** https://aissprogram.eu/scholarships/

2. Eligibility and scholarship rules (E1, re-read 8 Nov 2026)

- **Admission:**
  - a recognised bachelor’s degree plus an academic, professional or project background that supports the study path
  - education documents and transcript are assessed
  - documents count 50% (minimum 35/50); interview 50% (minimum 35/50); programme threshold 70/100
- **Scholarship:**
  - apply for it during admission
  - awarded only to the **10 highest-ranked** applicants
  - **at most 10% per nationality**
  - not combinable with another EU-funded Erasmus Mundus scholarship
  - you must study the full 24 months and meet the minimum mobility rules
  - **€1,400/month**, covering insurance, mobility travel, housing and food; tuition waived
- **English:** IELTS Academic or IELTS Online 6.5 (≥ 5.5 each); TOEFL iBT; PTE Academic 62 (≥ 59 each); Cambridge.
  - **An Ethiopian degree is not exempt.** The exemption covers only studies in the US, Canada, Australia, New Zealand, UK, Switzerland or the EU/EEA.

- **Your position:** eligible to apply. Competitive only through a strong portfolio, video and interview. **Not GPA-independent.**

3. Written and recorded responses (complete drafts)

3a. Motivation video script (≤ 1:30)

> [On camera, plain background. Your own voice; no speed-up.]
>
> Hello, I'm [name], from Addis Ababa, Ethiopia. For [⏳ N] years I have worked on the systems behind digital payments: the servers, pipelines and monitoring that let a shop accept a card or QR payment [⏳ keep only if accurate].
>
> When those systems fail, a merchant loses a day's income. That taught me that technology serves society only if it is reliable, and only if people trust it.
>
> AI is now entering these services: detecting fraud, predicting failures, deciding who gets credit. My research interest is how to bring AI into financial services in places like Ethiopia **responsibly**, and in particular how to design it **with** the merchants and users it affects, so it is fair and sustainable rather than only efficient.
>
> AISS is the programme that joins AI, sustainability and participatory design. I bring production experience in payment infrastructure. I want the methods to ask *who* a system serves and to build it with them.
>
> After AISS I will return to Ethiopia's digital-finance sector to design services people can rely on. Thank you.

Check before recording:

- under 1:30
- you are on screen at least half the time
- no AI voice
- uploaded as a link through DreamApply

3b. Research interests and thesis directions

Option	Research question (draft)	Why it is credible for you	AISS link
R1 (main)	How can AI-based fraud or anomaly detection in mobile and POS payments be designed with merchants so that false alarms do not exclude small businesses?	You work with merchant payment systems	AI + participatory design + inclusion
R2	Can monitoring data from payment platforms predict outages early enough to protect users in low-connectivity regions, and at what energy and compute cost?	You operate monitoring for payment services	AI for reliable, sustainable infrastructure
R3 (backup)	What do Ethiopian merchants need to trust automated decisions in digital finance? (a user study)	Your merchant-facing context	Human-centred AI

Thesis direction for the interview: R1 or R2. Say honestly that you will refine it with a supervisor; do not claim prior AI research.

3c. Social impact statement

> Ethiopia is moving quickly from cash to digital payments. For a small merchant or a family paying school fees, a reliable payment service is part of economic inclusion; a failed or unfair one excludes them. My work keeps such services running [⏳ verified role]. AI will increasingly decide inside these services: who looks fraudulent, who gets credit, which outage to fix first. My aim is to help make those decisions reliable, explainable and fair, by designing them with the merchants and users they affect and by keeping the infrastructure under them efficient enough to run sustainably in low-resource settings. After AISS I will bring this to Ethiopia's digital-finance sector [⏳ concrete plan].

AI claims rule:

- Say "I want to learn". Do not say "I am experienced in AI".
- Your evidence is one introductory AI course (grade B), plus production experience with the data that AI would use.

3d. Portfolio

The portfolio document is `09_AISS/AISS_Portfolio_Summaries` (5 executed projects, in AISS format). Export it as **one PDF**.

3e. Self-funding plan (mandatory)

Cost	Amount	Source
Tuition	**€8,000** (€2,000 × 4 semesters)	E1
Living costs (Estonia, Portugal, Finland)	[⏳ from the AISS "Living Costs" page; it did not load here]	E1 (fill in)
Travel between partner universities	[⏳]	–

Your funding sources (real only):

- savings [⏳]
- family [⏳]
- employer [⏳ only if a written offer exists]
- other scholarships applied for: Sweden SI, EDISS, Stipendium Hungaricum, CSC

Plan B (honest): "If I am not awarded the scholarship and cannot fund the costs, I will not enrol in 2027 and will reapply, or I will take a funded offer from another programme."

4. Documents and formats (E1)

Document	Format	Status
Education documents + transcript	PDF scans (issued in English; no translation needed)	You (scan)
Passport identification page	PDF	You
English evidence	IELTS / PTE / TOEFL result	**Book only once you confirm AISS**

Document	Format	Status
Motivation video	**≤ 1:30**, link submitted in DreamApply; you on screen at least half the time; own voice	Script 3a
Portfolio	One PDF of summaries (up to 5 projects); links allowed but not as a substitute	`AISS_Portfolio_Summaries`
CV	PDF	`06_FINAL_CV/CV_Europe_Academic`
Self-funding plan	PDF	3e

5. Outstanding items

1. Build demo repositories 3 and 4 (5 evenings).
2. Final-year project title + HR facts → portfolio and CV.
3. English test: decide and book.
4. Record the video.
5. Real figures for the self-funding plan.

6. Submission guide

1. From **2 Dec**, open the Application procedure page → DreamApply (Tallinn University) and create the account.
2. Choose AISS; **tick the Erasmus Mundus scholarship**.
3. Upload every document in section 4; submit the video link.
4. **Submit by 30 Jan** (deadline 2 Feb). AISS reviewers may give feedback on early applications.
5. If invited: 15-minute interview (10-minute presentation + 5 minutes of questions).

7. Interview

Presentation (3 slides at most, no reading):

1. **Who I am** (3 min): education, then infrastructure work, then one real incident or rollout story (STAR).
2. **What I want to explore** (4 min): R1 or R2, why it matters in Ethiopia, and what you need to learn (machine learning foundations, participatory methods, sustainability assessment).
3. **What I will do with it** (3 min): career plan in Ethiopia's digital finance.

Likely questions, with answer outlines:

Question	Outline (use your real facts)
Why AISS and not a pure computer-science master's?	You need AI + society + design together; your problems are socio-technical

Question	Outline (use your real facts)
Your grades are average. Why should we select you?	Upward trend (final year 3.20); strong A− in demanding courses; years of production responsibility; the portfolio shows execution
What is participatory design?	Involving the people affected throughout design. Give an example: merchants co-defining fraud-alert rules
Which AI methods do you know?	Be honest: introductory AI course (B); you will build the foundations in year 1. Name what you have read
A project that failed?	A real incident: what you changed afterwards
How is your work linked to sustainability?	Financial inclusion (SDG 8), resilient infrastructure (SDG 9); energy cost of computing
Which mobility track and why?	Choose after reading the track pages; link it to R1 or R2
If you get no scholarship?	Your self-funding plan: honest (section 9)
How will you use the degree in Ethiopia?	A specific role and problem, not “help my country” in general
Teamwork in a multicultural group?	A real example of working with colleagues or partner banks

Practice: three mock sessions with me (record yourself; no notes on screen).

8. Final audit checklist

- ☐ Video ≤ 1:30; on screen at least 50%; no AI voice; not sped up
- ☐ Portfolio is a summary PDF (not a list of links), up to 5 items, each explained
- ☐ No extra files uploaded
- ☐ English result meets 6.5 / each part ≥ 5.5 (IELTS) or the equivalent
- ☐ Self-funding plan included
- ☐ Scholarship box ticked
- ☐ Submitted by 30 Jan; confirmation saved